Social Media Quality Tips

24 tips for clearer, sharper videos

Scrolly

Contents

	Free fixes first, gear if you want it	3
LIGHT		
1	Face a window	4
2	Pick soft light over bright light	4
3	Turn off the overhead lights	4
CAMERA SETTINGS		
4	Use the back camera	4
5	Wipe your lens	5
6	Record and export in standard color	5
7	Use 30 fps, and one rate per Reel	5
8	Step back, then zoom	5
9	Lock your exposure, and know what focus lock does	6
10	Use Cinematic mode well	7
FRAMING		
11	Film at eye level, and see yourself	8
VISUAL HOOKS		
12	Open with movement	9
13	Open with a surprise	10
14	Show the result first	11
SOUND		
15	Record in a soft room	11
16	Get the mic close	11
17	Clean up your audio after you film	12
18	Keep music under your voice	12
EDITING		
19	Edit for free in the Edits app	13
20	Use a template	14
UPLOAD QUALITY		
21	Upload at highest quality	14
22	Export in SDR, at your filming frame rate	15
23	Fix blurry Canva videos	15
24	Let it finish, then check the posted version	15
KEEP THESE HANDY		
	Quality checklist	16
	Troubleshooting	17
	Sources and credits	18

BEFORE YOU BUY ANYTHING

Free fixes first, gear if you want it

The phone you have is enough for every tip in this guide. The free fixes below make the biggest difference, and the gear list is here if you'd like it.

FREE, AND THEY MATTER MOST

- **Window light on your face** (tip 1)
- **Where you stand:** facing the light, a few steps from a tidy background (tips 1 and 8)
- **A wiped lens** (tip 5)
- **The back camera at 2x** (tips 4 and 8)
- **A soft room for sound,** like a bedroom or a closet full of clothes (tip 15)
- **Three upload settings** (tips 21 to 24)

HELPFUL GEAR, IF YOU WANT IT

Phone tripod with a remote	Steady shots at eye level, and you can start recording from where you stand.
Small LED light	For evenings and dark rooms. Place it beside the phone, pointed at your face.
Wired earbuds with a mic	The simplest way to get a mic close to your mouth.
Wireless clip-on mic	Clear sound from across a room or outdoors. Many kits come with a receiver that plugs into your phone's charging port.
Phone monitor screen	Attaches to your phone and shows you the picture, so you can film on the back camera and still see yourself (tip 11).

TIPS 1 TO 3

Light

1 Face a window

Stand or sit facing your biggest window, with the phone between you and the glass, its back toward the window. Soft daylight falls straight onto your face: clear detail, true color, and bright eyes. It's the biggest free upgrade in this guide.

Avoid the two common mistakes: a bright window behind you turns your face into a dark shape, because the camera sets its brightness for the glass; a window to one side leaves half your face in shadow, so turn toward it or hold a white card on the darker side.

2 Pick soft light over bright light

Direct sun makes squinting eyes and hard shadows. Film near a window on a cloudy day, step a little farther back from a sunny window, or hang a sheer curtain over it. Outdoors, open shade beside a building gives even, flattering light.

3 Turn off the overhead lights

Ceiling lights shine down from above and cast shadows under your eyes, and their warm color clashes with daylight. Switch them off and let the window do the work. For evening filming, a small LED light beside your phone, pointed at your face, gives a similar look.

TIPS 4 TO 10

Camera settings

4 Use the back camera

On most phones the back camera is the best one, with sharper detail and better color in low light. Tip 11 shows ways to see yourself while you film with it. The front camera still works when it's what you need.

5 Wipe your lens

Pockets and fingers leave a film on the lens that turns every light into a hazy glow. Wipe it with a soft cloth or the hem of a cotton shirt before every recording.

6 Record and export in standard color

HDR video from newer phones can look washed out, gray, or extra bright after it's edited and posted, because apps and screens handle HDR differently. Standard color (SDR) behaves more predictably from your camera roll to the posted Reel.

1. iPhone: **Settings → Camera → Record Video → HDR Video: off**. On Android, look for HDR or HDR10+ in the camera's video settings.
2. When you export, choose **SDR** (tip 22).
3. If a posted Reel still looks off, check that none of its clips were recorded in HDR before you turned the setting off.

7 Use 30 fps, and one rate per Reel

Start with 30 frames per second for talking and everyday clips, at 1080p or 4K. Switch to 60 fps for fast movement, like sports, pets, or quick hand demos. Keep every clip in a Reel at the same rate and export at that rate, so motion looks even. Uneven motion can also come from a shaky hand or a slow connection, so use a stand and check the posted version (tip 24).

iPhone: **Settings → Camera → Record Video**.

8 Step back, then zoom

Up close at 1x, the wide lens stretches faces a little and shows the whole room. Move the phone a few steps back and zoom in to fill the frame again: your face looks more natural and the background less busy.

Zoom quality depends on your phone. Many recent phones have a 2x setting that uses the main sensor or a telephoto lens and stays sharp; on others, 2x is a digital crop that softens the picture. Record five seconds at 1x and five at 2x, then compare them on your screen. In a small room, 1x from a little farther back works well too.

9 Lock your exposure, and know what focus lock does

On iPhone, touch and hold on your face until you see **AE/AF Lock**, then drag the sun icon down slightly so bright areas keep their detail.[1] Exposure lock stops the brightness from jumping when something bright passes behind you.

Focus lock fixes the focus at one distance. If you then walk toward or away from the camera, you'll go soft. Lock focus when you'll stay in place; for walk-ins and drop-ins, tap to set the exposure and leave focus on automatic. Tap the screen anywhere to unlock.

10 Use Cinematic mode well

Cinematic mode is built into the Camera app on supported iPhones. It keeps your subject sharp and blurs the background and foreground, and it follows faces automatically.[2] Check your camera's mode list: if "Cinematic" is there, your phone has it.

Control	What to do
Choose the mode	Open Camera and swipe to **Cinematic**.
Resolution and frame rate	Tap the values in the corner of the screen. Use 4K at 30 fps where your model offers it.
Lens and zoom	On supported models, tap 2x or 3x next to 1x. Pro models offer more zoom choices.
Depth	Tap the controls button, then **Depth**, and drag. A lower f number blurs the background more; a higher one keeps more of the scene sharp.
Exposure	Tap the controls button, then **Exposure**, and lower it slightly in bright light.
Focus	A yellow box marks who's in focus. Tap a gray box to switch people; tap again to lock on that person. Touch and hold to lock focus at one distance.

Set yourself up for it. Leave a few steps between you and the background, so the blur has room to show, and film in good light, which helps every video.

Test before the real take. Record 10 seconds while you talk and move your hands. Check your face, hands, hair edges, and glasses for blurry outlines or flicker. If edges look odd, raise the f number or step farther from the background.

Fix it afterward. In Photos, tap Edit to change the depth, change who's in focus at any moment, or turn the effect off.[3]

A CREATOR'S STARTING RECIPE

Some creators start with 4K at 30 fps, 2x if there's room, depth around f/6 so the face and hands stay fully sharp, and exposure lowered a little. Treat it as a first test and adjust by eye. More blur isn't automatically better; you want a calm background and a sharp, natural-looking you.

No Cinematic mode? Use the regular Video mode with the setup in tips 1, 5, and 8. Distance from the background softens it on any phone.

TIP 11

Framing

11 Film at eye level, and see yourself

Set the lens at eye level, with your eyes about a third of the way down the screen. The grid helps: **Settings → Camera → Grid**.

To see yourself on the back camera, a **phone monitor screen** attaches to your phone and shows the picture facing you. If you have an Apple Watch, the **Camera Remote** app works as a viewfinder and can start and stop video, within normal Bluetooth range of your iPhone.[4] Both are optional; a five-second test clip does the same job for free.

Visual hooks

People see your video before they read it. A visual hook gives their eyes a reason to stop in the first second, while your words pull them in. Pick one, film the opening a few times, and keep the take you'd stop for.

12 Open with movement

The drop-in

Start recording before you're in place, then step, sit, or lean into the frame as you start talking.

Try it: Fix-It Frank starts on a sagging gate, then steps in: "This gate is telling you something."

The walk-in

Film yourself from across the room, yard, or street walking toward the camera, as if someone caught you mid-day.

Try it: Sunday Supply Co. walks up the market aisle with a tote, then starts talking once she's close.

Object to the lens

Start with your product or tool moving toward the camera, then lower it to reveal you.

Try it: Golden Hour pushes a printed family photo toward the lens: "This took 45 minutes."

The hand swipe

Swipe your hand across the lens at the end of one clip and the start of the next. It reads as one smooth move between two scenes.

Try it: Paper & Pixel swipes from a blank card to the finished invitation.

13 Open with a surprise

The low-angle reveal

Put the phone low, or behind an object, then move the object away to reveal you or the product.

Try it: Paper & Pixel films from behind a stack of envelopes, then lifts them away.

The up-close start

Hold the phone a little below eye level and close, so your face fills the frame, and talk with your hands in view.

Try it: Ops Clarity opens close: "Your designer finished Tuesday. Why did the client get it Friday?"

The wired mic

Hold wired earbuds near your mouth as you talk. It gives a plain talking video a casual, recognizable look, and better sound too.

Try it: Golden Hour answers "What should we wear?" with her earbuds in hand.

An unusual spot

Film from somewhere unexpected: inside a toolbox, a cupboard, a shopping bag, or looking up from the floor.

Try it: Frank films from inside his toolbox as his hand reaches in for the right part.

Start mid-action

Skip the setup and begin in the middle of the work: the saw already cutting, the paint already on the brush.

Try it: Sunday Supply Co. starts mid-fold, with the tee halfway into the bag.

A quick zoom

In your editor, punch in on the first frame and ease out as you talk. A small move makes a still shot feel alive.

Try it: Ops Clarity zooms in on a messy whiteboard, then out to her at the desk.

14 Show the result first

Open on the finished thing, then show how you got there. People stay to see the before.

After, then before

Show the finished result for one second, then cut back to the start.

Try it: Frank opens on a straight, fresh fence, then cuts to the leaning one he started with.

Side by side

Split the screen: before on one side, after on the other, with the hook text above.

Try it: Golden Hour shows a phone snapshot beside the finished portrait.

TIPS 15 TO 18

Sound

15 Record in a soft room

Rugs, curtains, beds, and clothes soak up echo, while kitchens, bathrooms, and empty rooms bounce it around. For voiceovers, a closet full of clothes works like a small recording booth. Switch off fans and the dishwasher and silence notifications before you start.

16 Get the mic close

The closer the mic is to your mouth, the clearer and richer you sound. Within arm's length, your phone's own mic does a good job. Farther away, an optional mic helps:

- **Wired earbuds with a mic:** hold the mic near your chin.
- **A wireless clip-on mic** that connects to your phone: clip it to your collar, about a hand's width below your chin. Useful outdoors, across a room, or while you work.

17 Clean up your audio after you film

A free cleanup step can make a noisy room or an older phone sound noticeably better. It reduces steady noise like hum and hiss; it can't rescue speech that's buried under loud sound, so a quiet room still matters most.

- **Edits:** record your voiceover in the app (tap **Voice**), then use **Voice enhance** to enhance your voice and reduce noise.[5]
- **CapCut (free):** select a clip and look for **Reduce noise** in the bottom menu. Menu names can change between versions.
- **iPhone 16, iPhone 17, and iPhone Air:** video recorded with **Settings → Camera → Record Sound → Spatial Audio** can be adjusted afterward in Photos: tap Edit, then **Audio Mix**, then **Studio**, which reduces background sound and room echo.[6]
- **Re-record the words:** if the picture is great and the sound isn't, mute the clip and record a voiceover in a quiet closet.

18 Keep music under your voice

When you talk over music, lower the music until every word is easy to hear, then check on your phone's speaker, the way most people will hear it. In Edits, **Volume ducking** lowers the music automatically while you speak.[5] If the two compete, keep your voice.

Editing

19 Edit for free in the Edits app

Most Reels can be edited start to finish on your phone in **Edits**, Instagram's free editing app. It exports without a watermark[7] and covers what this plan needs:

- Trimming and splitting clips
- Captions for speech
- Text, stickers, and music
- Voiceovers with a script
- Voice enhance and ducking
- Color adjustments
- Green screen
- Export settings (tip 22)

Safe-zone guides. Creators show a **Show guides** switch in each project's settings (tap the project name at the top). Switch it on for every new project and keep text and faces inside the outline, so Instagram's buttons and caption won't cover them. If your version doesn't have it, use the safe-zone overlay from your Club downloads.

Then check the captions by hand. Read every line for spelling, especially names and prices, make sure each one stays on screen long enough to read, and keep them inside the safe area.

20 Use a template

A template copies another Reel's music and clip timing, and you drop in your own clips. Instagram can turn a Reel into a template when it has at least three clips, averaging under five seconds each, with music.[8] That makes templates a good fit for montages, before-and-afters, product reveals, and "day in the life" Reels.

FROM A REEL ON INSTAGRAM

1. On a Reel you like, tap **Use template**, shown on Reels that can be used as templates.
2. Choose your clips from your camera roll, in order.
3. Check the text: some templates bring it, many don't. Add or change it to your own words, then post.

MAKING IT BY HAND

1. Play the Reel you like and count its clips and how long each lasts.
2. In Edits, add the same number of clips and trim each to match. **Beats** markers on the music track help you line cuts up.
3. Add your own text and a song you're allowed to use.

Edits also offers templates in some countries. Save Reels you'd like to copy as you scroll, so you have a ready list on filming day.

TIPS 21 TO 24

Upload quality

Four different things affect how sharp a posted video looks: how you recorded it, how you exported it, its color format, and how Instagram processes it. This simple workflow keeps each one under control.

21 Upload at highest quality

When this setting is off, Instagram adjusts upload quality to your connection. Turn it on once and it stays on; uploads may take a little longer.[9]

Profile → ☰ menu → Media quality → Upload at highest quality: on

22 Export in SDR, at your filming frame rate

In Edits, tap the resolution in the top right of your project to choose resolution, frame rate, and color.[5] A reliable starting point: **1080p or higher, the same frame rate you filmed at, and SDR color**. Instagram asks for at least 720 pixels and 30 fps.[9] Some creators export at 4K and prefer how it looks after Instagram's processing; try both on one video and compare the posted results. In other editors, turn off any HDR export option.

23 Fix blurry Canva videos

1. **Start with sharp material.** Use full-size photos and clips inside your design. Small images stretched to fill the screen look blurry at any export setting.
2. Design at Instagram's size: **1080 × 1920 px** for Reels and Stories.
3. Download as an **MP4 video** at **1080p**. On the free plan, 1080p is the default; choosing another quality opens an upgrade prompt.[10]
4. Download once, save the file to your camera roll, and upload it from there with tip 21 turned on. Each extra download, re-save, or re-export through another app can soften it further.
5. Open the downloaded file on your phone and look closely at text edges before you post. If the download is already soft, fix the design or source images and download again.

24 Let it finish, then check the posted version

Post on Wi-Fi or a strong signal, and keep Instagram open until the upload completes. Instagram keeps processing for a short while after posting, so give it a few minutes, then open the posted Reel and compare it with your exported file. A second phone, or a friend's, gives you another view of what buyers see. Screens and connections vary, so look for clear problems, like soft text or washed-out color, and use the troubleshooting table to fix them.

KEEP THESE HANDY

Quality checklist

Run through these each time until they're habits. The numbers point to the tips.

BEFORE YOU FILM

- [ ] Lens wiped (5)
- [ ] Facing the light, ceiling lights off (1, 3)
- [ ] Back camera at eye level, framed with the grid (4, 11)
- [ ] Exposure locked if you'll stay still (9)
- [ ] 10-second test clip: watched and listened to (11, 15)
- [ ] Opening move planned: movement, surprise, or result (12 to 14)

BEFORE YOU EXPORT

- [ ] First frame shows the subject (12 to 14)
- [ ] Hook on screen in the first second
- [ ] Speech captions read and corrected (19)
- [ ] Text and faces inside the safe zone (19)
- [ ] Music under your voice (18)
- [ ] Export: SDR, your filming frame rate, 1080p or higher (22)

BEFORE AND AFTER POSTING

- [ ] Upload at highest quality is on (21)
- [ ] File uploaded from your camera roll (23)
- [ ] Wi-Fi or a strong signal; app open until it finishes (24)
- [ ] Posted version checked against your export (24)
- [ ] Anything off? Find it in Troubleshooting

KEEP THESE HANDY

Troubleshooting

What you see	Quick fix	Tip
My face is dark and the background glows	Turn around to face the window	1
Harsh shadows or squinting	Move to softer light: cloud, shade, or a sheer curtain	2
Shadows under my eyes, orange skin	Switch off the ceiling lights	3
Hazy glow around lights	Wipe the lens	5
Washed out, gray, or too bright once posted	Record and export in SDR; check for HDR clips	6, 22
Jerky or uneven motion	One frame rate for every clip, export at that rate, use a stand	7
My face looks wide, or the room looks busy	Step back and zoom; compare 1x and 2x	8
Brightness jumps, or I go blurry when I move	Lock exposure; leave focus on automatic for moving shots	9
Blurry edges around hair or hands in Cinematic mode	Raise the f number, step away from the background, add light	10
I'm off-center or cut off	Lens at eye level, grid on, a test clip or a viewfinder	11
People scroll past in the first second	Open with movement, a surprise, or the result	12 to 14
Echo or background noise	Soft room, mic closer, then Voice enhance or Reduce noise	15 to 17
Can't hear my voice over the music	Lower the music or use volume ducking	18
Text hidden by buttons, or captions with mistakes	Edit inside the safe zone; read and correct every caption line	19
Crisp in my camera roll, soft on Instagram	Upload at highest quality, export SDR at 1080p or higher, let it finish	21, 22, 24
Blurry Canva video	Sharp source images, one 1080p MP4 download, upload from the camera roll	23

Sources and credits

Small numbers in the tips point to these official pages, checked October 6, 2026. Menus change and not every option appears on every phone. If a path has moved, search the app's settings for the setting's name.

1. **Apple Support.** "Use iPhone camera tools to set up your shot (focus, exposure, AE/AF Lock)." support.apple.com/guide/iphone/set-up-your-shot-iph3dc593597/ios
2. **Apple Support.** "Record video in Cinematic mode with your iPhone camera." support.apple.com/guide/iphone/record-video-in-cinematic-mode-ipha0706e2bc/ios
3. **Apple Support.** "Edit Cinematic mode videos on iPhone." support.apple.com/guide/iphone/edit-cinematic-mode-videos-iph5e602f6d6/ios
4. **Apple Support.** "Use Camera Remote on Apple Watch." support.apple.com/guide/watch/camera-remote-apda6e61c287/watchos
5. **Instagram Help Center.** "Add or import music and audio to your Edits; Download and share your video from Edits (export settings)." help.instagram.com/458526493683638
6. **Apple Support.** "Change sound recording options on iPhone (Spatial Audio, Audio Mix)." support.apple.com/guide/iphone/change-sound-recording-options-iph31c1ca6c7/ios
7. **Meta for Creators.** "Introducing Edits, a video creation app (watermark-free export), April 22, 2025." creators.facebook.com/blog/edits-video-creation-app
8. **Instagram Help Center.** "Create a template for reels on Instagram." help.instagram.com/952015345862605
9. **Instagram Help Center.** "Reel size & aspect ratios on Instagram (minimums and Upload at highest quality)." help.instagram.com/1038071743007909
10. **Canva Help Center.** "Downloading designs as video or GIF." canva.com/help/download-as-video

Cover photos: Daniel & Hannah Snipes (Pexels), Rory Tucker and TuanAnh Blue (Unsplash). Fix-It Frank, Golden Hour Studio, Sunday Supply Co., Paper & Pixel, and Ops Clarity are illustrative businesses from the $1K Club Playbook.